time, the sanctity of the LoC in J&K and the LAC along our Himalayan borders has to be ensured.

Since the 1980s, India's neighbourhood has turned into a volatile, unstable and strife-prone region. Therefore, we have to be capable of defending our sovereignty and national integrity from both external and internal challenges and safeguard our national interests by an effective presence in the Indian Ocean region. The modernization and enhancement of the capability of our armed forces is an imperative need and this has to be done on priority. To address these major security concerns, the first step I took was to review the overall state of readiness of the army to carry out its assigned tasks for the defence of the nation. Were my formations and units adequately trained and equipped, and were the men well led and motivated? I visited all the important insurgency, and terrorism-affected and sensitive border areas, and met the formation commanders, other officers and troops to get a first-hand feel of the actual situation on the ground. Although I was fairly satisfied with many aspects, there were some issues that I felt had been inadequately addressed, or not in the way I would have liked. I was cognizant of the fact that the mantle of leading the Indian Army rested on my shoulders now, and that the buck would stop with me. Thus, I gave directions for improvement or making changes wherever necessary.

It was my impression that over the previous two decades, commencing from the early 1990s, our focus had shifted to our western border and J&K. The Kargil war in 1999 had accentuated the situation further as more formations, troops, weapons and equipment were moved to the Northern Command at the expense of the eastern theatre. Now, as the situation kept improving in J&K, there was an imperative need to restore the strategic imbalance and fill up the voids existing in the east. Accordingly, I ordered the reversion of units and formations to their areas in Eastern Command and also built up other assets like armoured and mechanized units, artillery and missiles, UAVs and aviation units. This process commenced in 2006. We were able to successfully achieve force restructuring, once the raising and validation of the operational